cowardly and irresolute, incapable of governing the empire. It sufficed for them to know that Muhammad Hakim was reputed to be sound in doctrine.'

Not all Mirza Hakim's officers were loyal to his cause, however, and one Mir Abu'l Qasim left Kabul to join Akbar's service. Since his lands lay within the Salt Range, he presented the Padshah with a plate and cup made of salt, to demonstrate his good intentions (namak-halali). He thus earned not only the Padshah's favour but also the sobriquet Namkin, or Salty.

Akbar responded to the challenge of the Afghans by sending Raja Todar Mal to the east but as the rebellion gathered momentum, through April 1580, Akbar finally recalled his long-neglected and rambunctious foster brother Mirza Aziz Koka. Ever since his truculence over the branding of horses, Aziz Koka, now titled khan azam and a mansabdar of 5,000, had been kept far away from the court. A witty, erudite, and orthodox man, Aziz Koka could never resist the temptation to contradict the Padshah and make plain his disapproval of all Akbar's religious innovations. Brought up in the camaraderie of their youth spent wrestling and camel-racing in Kabul, Aziz was entirely at ease with Akbar, one of the few amirs to truly ever be so. With his refined intelligence, and cool elegance, Aziz offered a study in contrast with Akbar, who was stocky and powerful, and possessed of a more intuitive understanding and magnetic warmth. 'Aziz was', according to Abu'l Fazl, 'remarkable for ease of address, intelligence, and his knowledge of history'. He wrote poetry and was credited with an aphorism of dubious merit that 'a man should marry four wives—a Persian woman to have somebody to talk to; a Khurasani woman for his housework; a Hindu woman for nursing his children; and a woman from Mawarannahr, to have someone to whip as a warning for the other three.' It was through the determined intercession of the harem (where Jiji Anaga must have made her feelings clear too) that Akbar heard that Aziz Koka was 'ashamed and repentant' and finally reinstated him.

Mirza Aziz Koka was now sent off to Bengal at the head of a large army and carrying 'those black standards, the sign of war to the death, which Timur the Lame…had been wont to employ in his wars' as a fluttering warning to the rebellious forces. But even with the enormous power of the Mughal force behind him it would be a few years before Bengal and Bihar were subdued. In 1580, Bihar was finally organized as a separate subah with 7 sarkars and 199 parganas 'yielding a revenue of about 22 crore dams or Rs. 5,547,985' and Mirza Aziz Koka became the first Subedar of Bihar.